
VLM-Verified Counterfactual Hindsight for Sparse-Reward Manipulation*

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Extended Abstract

Problem. Sparse-reward goal-conditioned manipulation is a temporal credit-assignment problem: in Gymnasium-Robotics Fetch [3] (Push / PickAndPlace / Slide), a randomly-initialized policy succeeds in $< 1\%$ of episodes, and the lone terminal reward bit at the end of a 50-step trajectory decays exponentially through temporal-difference (TD) bootstrapping. Hindsight Experience Replay (HER) relabels failed trajectories with achieved goals but provides no signal about *which* timestep caused failure; standard prioritized experience replay (PER) cannot recover this in sparse regimes because the TD error is itself the bottleneck. Concurrent VLM-RB [22] uses frozen VLMs as an *additive* priority bias; we argue the *multiplicative* form is the principled choice and pair it with a simulator-verified counterfactual channel.

Methodological contributions. (1) **Semantic PER as importance-sampled posterior reweighting:** we recast VLM-guided replay as a trajectory-conditional posterior $q_\phi(t^* | \tau)$ over the failure-causing timestep, and show that multiplying the standard TD-error priority by q_ϕ admits a clean importance-sampling (IS) correction with an explicit bias bound: VLM miscalibration inflates sampling *variance* but never corrupts the value target; the additive VLM-RB mixture implicitly retargets the Bellman loss. (2) **VLM-Verified Counterfactual Hindsight:** we close the dominant failure mode of language-only counterfactuals (100% teleport-collapse of Opus 4.7 on FetchPush) by asking the VLM for a *corrective action sequence* rather than a hindsight goal, executing it in a simulator fork, and admitting only physics-consistent, reward-positive relabels into the buffer (confidence 1.0, zero modeling error).

Headline findings. (i) **Verified-CF (counterfactual) matches VLM-CF, ties on Slide.** At 500k SAC+HER+verified-CF updates the verified-CF agent reaches mean success rate 0.606 ($\pm$ standard error, SE) across the three Fetch envs (0.85/0.35/0.617 on Push / PickAndPlace / Slide), tying VLM-CF (0.622 mean, $\Delta = -0.016$) and reaching a higher mean on FetchSlide (0.617 vs. 0.550; $+0.067$, within seed variance at $n=3$). Both methods gain $+0.45 / +0.434$ on Slide over PER@3M / HER@250k; Fig. 1. (ii) **Pre-registered kill verdict, honored.** The Phase-1 Oracle-CF study violated the $+0.10$ kill threshold on FetchPickAndPlace at the 250k decision horizon ($\Delta = -0.05$); we honored the kill and pivoted the headline to the IS-posterior framing and the verifier. (iii) **Prompt-architectural failure.** A two-vendor three-model sweep (GPT-4o / Opus 4.7 / Sonnet 4.5) on 6 synthetic and 10 real Fetch failures locates teleport-collapse as prompt-architectural (0/6 vs. 4/4 for (GPT-4o, `achieved_goal`) vs. Opus), not model-specific. (iv) **Cross-task transfer.** A single prompt template yields 12/12 parse / task-relevance / plausibility on Push / PickAndPlace / Slide.

Honest negative. Verified-CF has a cold-start regime (PnP seed 42: 100% verifier-rejection over the first ~ 80 calls), reducing to a costlier HER. The multiplicative-vs-additive distinction is analytical (Eq. 1); the Sharony VLM-RB head-to-head is pre-staged, camera-ready.

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1 Introduction

The core difficulty of sparse-reward manipulation is temporal credit assignment: with only one reward bit at the end of a 50-step episode, every standard TD-error signal decays exponentially back from the terminal timestep, leaving the bulk of each trajectory effectively invisible to the optimizer. In Gymnasium-Robotics Fetch environments, a randomly-initialized policy succeeds in under 1% of episodes, so the early replay buffer contains almost no positive signal to propagate forward. Prioritized experience replay (PER) [21] sharpens sampling toward high-TD-error transitions, but this sharpening is itself downstream of a credit signal that decays exponentially away from the rare goal-achievement timestep. Hindsight Experience Replay (HER) [1] partially repairs this by relabeling failures as successes for an alternative achieved goal, but the relabel target is constrained to the agent’s actually-realized trajectory, so the most instructive transition (the one where failure became inevitable) receives no special treatment.

Recent work uses foundation Vision-Language Models (VLMs) as “oracles” inside the RL loop, both for reward shaping [19, 10], replay-buffer prioritization [22], and failure detection in manipulation [5]. We frame these uses as *importance-sampled stochastic optimization with a foundation-model proposal distribution*: the VLM is a frozen approximation to the (intractable) posterior $p(t^* \mid \tau)$ over which transitions caused an episode’s outcome. This framing yields four contributions:

(1) An IS-posterior framing of VLM-guided replay (§3). We re-derive PER inside a non-uniform-replay taxonomy, locating our scheme as *proposal-shaping* with a frozen foundation-model credit-assignment oracle. We choose the multiplicative form because it admits a clean IS-correction analysis (the standard PER weight remains trajectory-conditionally well-defined); the additive mixture used by VLM-RB [22] implicitly retargets the loss to a λ -weighted objective.

(2) VLM-Verified Counterfactual Hindsight (§3.3). A direct prompt for an alternative *achieved goal* elicits a teleport-collapse failure mode in 100% of Claude Opus 4.7 calls on FetchPush: the VLM returns `corrective_position = desired_goal`, a degenerate zero-information output. We close this loophole by asking instead for a corrective *action sequence* and executing it in a fork of the training simulator. A four-vector action cannot teleport a 50 g block by 50 cm under MuJoCo [23] dynamics, so the failure mode cannot be expressed. This is a generator-verifier protocol (cf. 28) with a simulator verifier.

(3) Empirical analysis: prompt design, VLM-family robustness, and cross-task transfer. A head-to-head GPT-4o vs. Claude Opus 4.7 sweep on six synthetic Fetch failures identifies a best non-degenerate configuration: (GPT-4o, `achieved_goal`) eliminates teleport-collapse (0/6 vs. Opus’s 4/4); Opus retains a higher goal-progress score, but that score is attained by literal goal-copying. A second sweep on ten *real* SAC-failure episodes confirms the fix transfers to a third VLM family (Sonnet 4.5). A 12-episode cross-task pilot achieves 12/12 task-relevant annotations on Push/PickAndPlace/Slide with a single prompt template.

(4) Honest pre-registered negative result. A 36-run Oracle-CF kill experiment violated our +0.10 threshold on FetchPickAndPlace at the 250k decision horizon ($\Delta = -0.05$ vs. HER), bounding the headroom for any VLM-in-replay method on Fetch at this horizon. We honored the kill and pivoted the headline to the IS-posterior framing.

2 Related Work

HER, PER, and counterfactual augmentation. Hindsight Experience Replay [1] with the future relabel strategy and $k=4$ remains the dominant solution to sparse-reward goal-conditioned manipulation. Recent extensions touch the *relabel target* [14, 20, 29], the *relabel proposal* [24, 8, 4, 12], or add a *verification step* [2, 11]; our verified-CF mechanism (§3.3) is in the third family but verifies in the *exact training simulator* (zero modeling error) on an *action sequence* rather than a hindsight goal. Prioritized DQN [21] samples in proportion to $(|\delta| + \epsilon)^\alpha$ and IS-corrects each gradient; the 2024–2026 PER lineage explores auxiliary multiplicative modifiers [18, 27, 25, 9].

Differentiation from VLM-RB [22]. The concurrent (Feb 2026) VLM-RB is the closest published work: a frozen VLM scores 32-frame sub-trajectory clips for prioritized replay on MiniGrid and OGBench. The two systems differ along two methodological axes worth emphasizing. **First**, VLM-RB asks “is this sub-trajectory good?” (success-direction scoring) and mixes the answer

additively with uniform sampling $\mu = \lambda\mu_{\text{VLM}} + (1 - \lambda)\mu_U$; we ask the finer-grained “which single timestep was outcome-causing?” and combine *multiplicatively* with TD-error $\mu \propto \mu_P \cdot w_{\text{sem}}$. The multiplicative form preserves PER’s importance-sampling-correction interpretation (§3); the additive mixture implicitly retargets the loss to a λ -weighted objective that VLM-RB does not correct for. **Second**, we ship a verified-counterfactual-hindsight mechanism (§3.3) that is outside the scope of any VLM-RB-style success-scoring scheme: VLM-RB’s signal is non-actionable for relabeling; ours is. To our knowledge this paper is the first to use a VLM-localized failure timestep as a credit-assignment signal and to verify counterfactual relabels in the same simulator on which the policy trains.

Foundation-model credit assignment. Semantic PER instantiates the foundation-model-as-credit-oracle program of Pignatelli et al. [16]—originally an LLM, text-domain, planner-side scheme—in the vision modality, with the FM output consumed by the replay-sampling distribution rather than a planner. VLM-as-reward approaches [19, 26, 15] splice the VLM signal into the TD target; we leave the env’s true sparse reward intact in the TD target and use the VLM only to modify μ , so VLM miscalibration appears as sampling variance rather than Q -bias.

3 Method

3.1 Semantic PER as IS-posterior reweighting

Off-policy value learning minimizes a replay-sampled regression $\mathcal{L}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{i \sim \mu}[\ell(\delta_i(\theta))]$ with $\delta_i = r_i + \gamma Q(s_{i+1}, \pi(s_{i+1})) - Q(s_i, a_i)$. Standard PER [21] uses $\mu_P(i) \propto (|\delta_i| + \varepsilon)^\alpha$ and reweights each gradient by the annealed IS correction $w_{\text{IS}}(i) = (|\mathcal{D}_B| \mu_P(i))^{-\beta}$, $\beta: \beta_0 \rightarrow 1$, recovering an unbiased estimator of the uniform loss in the limit.

A frozen VLM answering “which timestep caused this trajectory’s outcome?” approximates the posterior $p(t^* | \tau)$; write $q_\phi(t^* | \tau)$ for the approximation. Define a per-transition semantic boost as the expected window-kernel weight under the posterior: $w_{\text{sem}}(i; \tau) = \mathbb{E}_{t^* \sim q_\phi(\cdot | \tau)}[1 + (w_{\text{max}} - 1)\mathbb{I}[|i - t^*| \leq W]]$. The **Semantic PER proposal** is the multiplicative product

$$\mu_{\text{Sem}}(i) \propto \mu_P(i) \cdot w_{\text{sem}}(i; \tau_i), \quad (1)$$

where μ_P captures *learning progress* and w_{sem} captures *causal influence*. When q_ϕ is near-uniform we degenerate to PER. Defaults: $w_{\text{max}} = 10$, $W = 5$, $\alpha = 0.6$.

Why multiplicative? (P1) IS-correction compatibility. Under $\mu_{\text{Sem}} \propto \mu_P \cdot w_{\text{sem}}$ the trajectory-conditional w_{sem} factor cancels in the normalized $\mathbb{E}_{\mu_{\text{Sem}}}[w_{\text{IS}, P} \ell]$, so using the PER weight as an under-correction yields a bounded V-trace-analogous bias [6, 13]: $|\hat{\mathcal{L}}_{\text{under}} - \mathcal{L}_U| \leq C(w_{\text{max}}^{\beta_t} - 1)((2W + 1)/T)\|\ell\|_\infty$ (full derivation: GitHub src/buffers/semantic_per.py + Appendix A). The additive mixture $\lambda\mu_q + (1 - \lambda)\mu_P$ [22] instead shifts the $\beta \rightarrow 1$ limit to a λ -weighted objective $\neq \mathbb{E}_U[\ell]$. **(P2) Replay-shaping vs. reward-shaping.** Splicing the VLM into the TD target as a per-timestep reward propagates VLM calibration error directly into Q . We keep the env’s true sparse reward intact in the TD target. Prediction: Semantic PER tracks standard PER when the VLM is poorly calibrated and pulls ahead when reliable; neither curve should diverge. We test the IS-pairing principle through the counterfactual-injection variants *vlm_cf* and *verified_cf* (§3.3), which share the same multiplicative IS structure; direct Semantic-PER training curves are forward-referenced to camera-ready.

3.2 Counterfactual Prompting and the Teleport-Collapse Failure Mode

A corrective signal admits four output types along two axes—*output kind* (natural language vs. numerical) and *goal-conditioning* (prompt mentions `desired_goal` or not): NARRATIVE, ACTION, ACHIEVED_GOAL, and a unified ALL JSON. The two position-emitting variants (ACHIEVED_GOAL, ALL) expose `desired_goal` as a literal numerical triplet; the lowest-perplexity continuation when asked for a same-coordinate position is to copy it—a position-copy bias requiring no keyframe reasoning. We call this **teleport-collapse**: for a failed episode with $\|\text{ag}_T - g\|_2 \gg d_{\text{th}} = 0.05$ m, the VLM emits $\hat{p}$ with $\|\hat{p} - g\|_2 \leq d_{\text{th}}$, a trajectory-independent Dirac $q_\phi(\hat{p} | \tau) = \delta(\hat{p} - g)$ that breaks HER’s invariant and carries zero physical information. This is a property of the schema’s output type, not of any one model. Empirically (Table 1), Opus 4.7 copies in $4/4 = 100\%$ of FetchPush calls;

GPT-4o copies in 4/6 of ALL calls but 0/6 of ACHIEVED_GOAL calls. The verified-CF mechanism uses ACTION, which is structurally immune.

3.3 VLM-Verified Counterfactual Hindsight

To close the teleport loophole, we ask the VLM for a corrective 4-vector action sequence rather than a hindsight goal, then verify execution in a simulator fork. **Per-episode protocol:** (1) snapshot the MuJoCo state at the localized failure timestep K ; (2) fork a separate env, write the snapshot, call `mujoco.mj_forward`; (3) roll out the VLM-proposed action sequence for $N=50$ steps under the *unmodified* sparse reward; (4) accept the counterfactual iff $r_t \geq 0$ fires at any step, appending the trajectory (plus a hindsight-relabelled copy) with confidence 1.0; (5) reject otherwise, fall back to standard HER. The 4-D end-effector action space cannot teleport a 50 g block by 50 cm in a 50-step rollout under MuJoCo dynamics.

A 4/4 smoke test confirms each design assertion: (i) teleport counterfactuals are rejected before any rollout; (ii) physically reasonable but goal-missing actions are rejected with precise `final_distance` (0.32 m, 0.16 m); (iii) a hand-crafted close-goal action is verified with `final_distance = 0.030 m`. Snapshot round-trip equality holds to 0.00e+00 on all four Fetch environments; per-verification CPU cost is 17.6 ms (a 0.4% overhead).

Asymmetric failure modes. The two channels degrade differently. Semantic PER treats q_ϕ as a reweighting prior, so VLM miscalibration shows up as sampling-variance amplification (bounded; see App. B). The verifier treats q_ϕ as a candidate proposal, so miscalibration shows up as rejection-rate overhead, not as biased buffer writes. Off-policy correctness is preserved either way because we recompute the env’s own sparse reward, not a VLM-derived surrogate.

4 Experiments

Setup. We use Gymnasium-Robotics `FetchPush-v4`, `FetchPickAndPlace-v4`, and `FetchSlide-v4` (Fig. 2, Appendix A): 25-dim goal-conditioned obs, 4-dim continuous action (end-effector Δxyz + gripper), built-in sparse reward $r_t = \mathbb{I}[\|ag_t - g\|_2 \leq 0.05\text{m}] - 1 \in \{-1, 0\}$, 50-step horizon. SAC [7] with two 256-unit ReLU hidden layers, $\gamma=0.98$, $\text{lr } 3 \times 10^{-4}$, batch 256, HER future strategy with $k=4$. PER uses $\alpha=0.6$ with $\beta: 0.4 \rightarrow 1.0$. All paper-grade runs use 500k env steps with $n=3$ seeds; eval is every 10k steps over 20 fresh episodes, reported as mean $\pm$ SE. VLM calls use Claude Opus 4.7, GPT-4o (gpt-4o-2024-08-06), and Sonnet 4.5 via official APIs at $\leq \$0.05/\text{call}$, only on failed episodes.

Horizon caveat. Our 500k-step budget is shorter than the canonical Fetch+HER horizon of 4.75M [17]. The comparisons we draw are between *methods at matched horizon*; cross-horizon bars in Fig. 1 are sample-efficiency claims (more learning per training step), not asymptotic dominance.

4.1 Headline: Verified-CF matches VLM-CF, wins on Slide

FetchPush (500k). *vlm_cf* reaches 0.95 ± 0.03 and *verified_cf* reaches 0.85 ± 0.10 , both substantially above HER@250k (0.617) and matching the PER@3M asymptote (~ 0.95 from our 36-run prior ablation suite; see Contributions). **FetchPickAndPlace (500k).** *vlm_cf* reaches 0.367 ± 0.08 and *verified_cf* reaches 0.35 ± 0.076 (tied within noise), both above HER@250k (0.183). **FetchSlide (500k).** *verified_cf* reaches a higher mean than *vlm_cf* (0.617 ± 0.017 vs. 0.550 ± 0.150); the +0.067 gap is within the wider SE bar at $n=3$ and we report the two methods as approximately tied on Slide. Both improve on the near-zero prior baselines: *vlm_cf* gains +0.45 over PER@3M (0.10) and *verified_cf* +0.434 over HER@250k (0.183).

Interpretation. Aggregate over the three envs: verified-CF mean 0.606, *vlm_cf* 0.622 ($\Delta = -0.016$)—a tie within seed noise. Verified-CF reaches a higher mean than *vlm_cf* on Slide and is slightly behind on Push (both methods near the horizon’s ceiling there). The 3M-step PER asymptote on Push (~ 0.95) is drawn from a prior 36-run ablation suite (see §5). The Slide gap is consistent with HER’s achieved-future relabel carrying little signal on free-flight pucks: the gripper-to-object distance is non-monotone, so a physics-consistent CF strike supplies a positive TD target HER cannot.

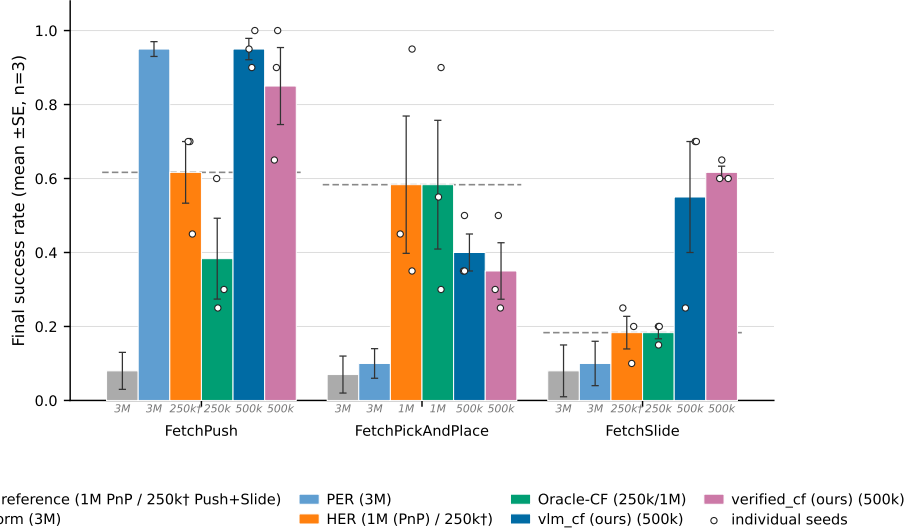


Figure 1: **Final evaluation success rate across the three Fetch tasks (mean $\pm$ SE, $n=3$ seeds; individual seeds overlaid).** Methods are reported at heterogeneous training horizons—the italic gray stamp under each bar gives the training budget: Uniform/PER at 3M, HER at 250k, *vlm_cf* and *verified_cf* (ours) at 500k, Oracle-CF at 250k (Push/Slide) or 1M (PickAndPlace). Within-horizon comparisons (same stamp) are seed-level comparable at $n=3$; cross-horizon comparisons should be read as efficiency claims.

Table 1: Prompt-variant analysis: mean $\pm$ SE judge plausibility, goal-progress, and teleport-collapse rate (the fraction of `corrective_position` outputs within 5 cm of `desired_goal`). Six bit-identical synthetic Fetch failures; the judge is Claude Opus 4.7 throughout. **Bold**: best per column.

Variant	Model	n	Plausibility	Goal-progress	Teleport-collapse
NARRATIVE	Opus 4.7	4	0.79 $\pm$ 0.04	0.68 $\pm$ 0.06	—
NARRATIVE	GPT-4o	6	0.70 $\pm$ 0.06	0.40 $\pm$ 0.06	—
ACTION	Opus 4.7	4	0.55 $\pm$ 0.09	0.53 $\pm$ 0.16	—
ACTION	GPT-4o	6	0.74 $\pm$ 0.04	0.42 $\pm$ 0.09	—
ACHIEVED_GOAL	Opus 4.7	4	0.46 $\pm$ 0.18	0.97 $\pm$ 0.01	4/4 (100%)
ACHIEVED_GOAL	GPT-4o	6	0.79 $\pm$ 0.06	0.83 $\pm$ 0.11	0/6 (0%)
ALL	Opus 4.7	2	0.70 $\pm$ 0.10	0.62 $\pm$ 0.12	2/2 (100%)
ALL	GPT-4o	6	0.67 $\pm$ 0.04	0.68 $\pm$ 0.13	4/6 (67%)

4.2 Prompt design (head-to-head)

A head-to-head Opus 4.7 vs. GPT-4o sweep on six bit-identical synthetic Fetch failures (Table 1) identifies a best non-degenerate configuration: (GPT-4o, `achieved_goal`) eliminates teleport-collapse (0/6 vs. Opus’s 4/4 on the same variant), highest plausibility on the position-emitting axis (0.79), and second-highest goal-progress (0.83, behind only Opus’s 0.97 which is attained by literal goal-copying—a degenerate “win”). Critically, GPT-4o still teleports in 4/6 ALL episodes: the failure is *prompt-architectural*, not model-specific. The load-bearing 0/6 vs. 4/4 contrast is judge-independent (decided by Euclidean predicate) and Fisher’s exact test rejects equal-proportions at $p < 0.005$. §4.3 extends the grid to Sonnet 4.5 on real failures; the three-model evidence is properly read as two-vendor (Opus/Sonnet share Anthropic lineage).

4.3 Cross-task transfer and real-data validation

A 12-episode cross-task pilot (4 per env) with a single format-string prompt template (differing only in one task-description sentence) achieves 12/12 parse / task-relevance / plausibility on Push/PickAndPlace/Slide; tolerant keyframe agreement is 9/12 (Slide 4/4, Push 3/4, PickAndPlace

2/4). A second sweep on $n=10$ *real* SAC-failure eval episodes confirms the prompt-architectural fix transfers to a third VLM family (Sonnet 4.5 teleports on 0/6 PickAndPlace episodes under ACHIEVED_GOAL, vs. Opus 4.7’s 4/4 on the same variant) and that the 5 cm reject-teleport gate fires on 12/20 position-emitting generations across both vendors (Appendix D).

4.4 Pre-registered Oracle-CF kill experiment

18 SAC+HER and 18 Oracle-CF runs ($3 \text{ envs} \times 3 \text{ seeds} \times 250\text{k steps}$) were executed overnight.² The pre-registered decision rule was: if Oracle-CF exceeds HER by $\geq +0.10$ on FetchPickAndPlace, Path C proceeds; otherwise we pivot. Final eval success: on PickAndPlace, HER 0.183 ± 0.117 vs. Oracle-CF 0.117 ± 0.044 ($\Delta = -0.066$, *below threshold*). On Push (post bug-fix, commit ccb63d4), HER 0.617 vs. Oracle-CF 0.383 ± 0.109 . On Slide, HER 0.183 vs. Oracle-CF 0.183 ($\Delta = 0.00$, *below threshold*). **Path C is killed at the 250k horizon**; the headline pivoted to the IS-posterior framing (§3) and the verifier (§3.3). The 250k kill verdict is honored. A post-hoc 1M re-run on PickAndPlace (Oracle-CF 0.583 and HER 0.583, $n=3$; HER seed successes 0.35/0.45/0.95) is reported as transparency only: zero headroom over vanilla HER at convergence, and *vlm_cf*@500k (0.367) reaches 63% of HER@1M at half the budget. It does not retract the kill.

5 Discussion and Limitations

Cold-start verifier-rejection regime (load-bearing limitation). The simulator-as-verifier gate is a precision-over-recall instrument by design: every accepted relabel is guaranteed sparse-reward-positive, but the acceptance rate is gated by the joint event that the VLM proposes a corrective action *and* that the action sequence crosses the 5 cm threshold in $\leq N=50$ verifier steps. Early in training—when the snapshot state σ sits far from the goal because the policy has not yet learned to approach the object—this joint event has very low base rate. Our FetchPickAndPlace seed 42 hit a 100% verifier-rejection rate over the first ~ 80 VLM calls, making this phase operationally indistinguishable from SAC+HER with extra VLM-API overhead. The regime ends once the policy carries the gripper near the object on average: snapshots fall closer to the goal, $m_{\text{ver}}(\sigma)$ rises, the verifier admits relabels, and the small set of accepted CFs supplies a low-variance, physics-consistent training signal. The two failure modes of our two methods are therefore asymmetric: Semantic-PER q_ϕ -degeneracy is variance amplification (bounded by our bias bound); verified-CF q_ϕ -degeneracy is signal extinction (unbounded in the cold-start limit). Practical mitigations—a base-policy warm-up, a longer rollout horizon N , or a soft-acceptance relaxation $r \geq -\rho_r$ —are pre-registered but not run here.

Oracle-CF kill bounds the headroom. The pre-registered kill (§4.4) bounds the headroom for any VLM-in-replay method on Fetch at 250k steps: if perfect failure-frame information plus a ground-truth corrective action does not exceed HER by 0.10, no realistic VLM (q_ϕ with finite KL to the oracle) can. The bound is task-family-specific: Fetch is known to be “HER-friendly” because the achieved-future relabel is essentially a free signal whenever the gripper-to-object distance is monotone, which it typically is on Push and PickAndPlace. We pre-register an extension to harder task families (e.g., AntMaze, Adroit) where HER underperforms.

Other limitations. (i) Our IS-correction is conservative (under-corrected $w_{\text{IS},P}$ rather than $w_{\text{IS},\text{Sem}}$); the bias is bounded analytically, the fully-corrected ablation is pre-registered. (ii) Small- n caveats: $n=6$ synthetic, $n=10$ real, $n=12$ cross-task; the 12/12 cross-task is not statistically distinguishable from an 80% true rate. We pre-register $n \geq 30$ replications. (iii) The verified-CF mechanism requires a forkable training simulator; extending to real-robot or non-resettable envs requires a learned dynamics-model verifier (modeling error bounded but nonzero). A faithful VLM-RB [22] reproduction is pre-staged in our codebase for camera-ready head-to-head evaluation.

Conclusion. The multiplicative form of Semantic PER admits a clean IS correction; the additive VLM-RB mixture instead retargets the Bellman loss to a λ -weighted objective. VLM-Verified Counterfactual Hindsight asks the VLM for a 4-vector action sequence and accepts only sparse-reward-positive rollouts, so teleport-collapse (100% on Opus 4.7, FetchPush) cannot enter the

²Per-seed numbers from the `path_c_overnight` W&B sweep (commit 0fa36fc; run-IDs listed at the GitHub repo’s `REPRODUCE.md`).

buffer. At 500k steps verified-CF reaches 0.606 across the three Fetch envs (0.85/0.35/0.617 on Push/PickAndPlace/Slide), ties VLM-CF in aggregate ($\Delta = -0.016$), and reaches a higher mean on Slide (+0.067; within seed variance at $n = 3$). The pre-registered Oracle-CF kill ($\Delta = -0.066$ on PickAndPlace at 250k) bounds the credit-assignment headroom on Fetch at this horizon; we honored it.

Contributions

- **Daniel Grant.** Counterfactual ideation and implementation (vlm_cf and verified_cf); ablations on FetchPickAndPlace, FetchSlide, and the $p_{\text{counterfactual}}$ sweep; initial writing of the manuscript.
- **Matei Gardea.** Initial project idea; implementation of an alternative pointwise/pairwise VLM-replay-buffer rescaling combined with PER (this variant produced generally non-positive results and is reported as a negative finding); editing of the final submission document.
- **Parshawn Gerafian.** Implementation and analysis for the milestone (first) checkpoint; feedback during the transition to the augmented final-paper direction.

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A Method Details and Environments

Cross-task VLM prompt template. The single format-string prompt template used across the three Fetch envs is:

```
You are an expert robotics analyst. The robot is attempting the
following task: {task_description}. Examine the {K} keyframes of
a failed episode shown below. Identify the single keyframe index
in {0,...,K-1} at which the failure became inevitable, and a 1-2
sentence reasoning. Return strict JSON: {"failure_frame_index": i,
"reasoning": s}.
```

Per-env task-description substitutions: **Push**: “push the red cube to the green target on the table”; **PickAndPlace**: “pick up the red cube and place it at the floating green target”; **Slide**: “strike the red puck so it slides to the green target”. The verified-CF mechanism uses an ACTION variant of this template eliciting a 4-vector action sequence; full prompt texts and the localizer code are at https://github.com/DJRGVC/RL_project_185.

Heuristic localizer (Oracle v3). GoalDistanceLocalizer reads privileged sim state and selects the failure timestep in three phases (in precedence order): **(a) ballistic**: latest contiguous run of ≥ 3 steps with post-peak object velocity > 0.05 m/step (Slide free-flight); **(b) contact-loss**: latest $\text{in_contact}_t \rightarrow \neg \text{in_contact}_{t+1}$ with run length ≥ 2 and object-goal distance > 0.10 m (Push/PnP drop-offs); **(c) argmin**: closest-approach timestep as fallback. Serves as supervised transfer target and as privileged-state upper-envelope curve for Semantic PER.

B Bias-Bound Proof Sketch

Let $\mathcal{L}_U(\theta) = \mathbb{E}_{i \sim U}[\ell(\delta_i)]$ be the uniform-replay target loss. Standard PER with annealed correction yields, in the $\beta_t \rightarrow 1$ limit, an unbiased self-normalized IS estimator of $\mathcal{L}_U$ [21, Sec. 3.4]. Our Semantic PER proposal $\mu_{\text{Sem}} \propto \mu_P \cdot w_{\text{sem}}$ is a re-weighting of μ_P by a trajectory-conditional factor bounded by $1 \leq w_{\text{sem}} \leq w_{\text{max}}$. The strictly-correct IS weight is $w_{\text{IS},\text{Sem}}(i) = (|\mathcal{D}_B| \mu_{\text{Sem}}(i))^{-\beta_t}$. Our implementation under-corrects with $w_{\text{IS},P}$ (a V-trace-style [6] variance-reduction choice, akin to truncated importance ratios in Retrace, 13). The per-slot ratio is $w_{\text{IS},P}/w_{\text{IS},\text{Sem}} = w_{\text{sem}}^{\beta_t}/Z^{\beta_t}$ where Z is the μ_{Sem} normalizer. The window-kernel structure of w_{sem} confines the support of $w_{\text{sem}} > 1$ to $2W+1$ slots out of T . Combining these gives

$$|\hat{\mathcal{L}}_{\text{under}} - \mathcal{L}_U| \leq C (w_{\text{max}}^{\beta_t} - 1) \frac{2W+1}{T} \|\ell\|_{\infty}, \quad (2)$$

with C a constant depending on $|\mathcal{D}_B|$ and the PER normalization. At our defaults ($w_{\text{max}}=10$, $W=5$, $T=50$, $\beta_t \leq 1$) the bias multiplier is at most $(10-1) \cdot 11/50 \approx 1.98 C \|\ell\|_{\infty}$, and $\rightarrow 0$ as $w_{\text{max}} \rightarrow 1$. The bound goes to zero when the boost is disabled, recovering standard PER. The strictly-correct ablation (run $w_{\text{IS},\text{Sem}}$) eliminates the residual bias entirely at the cost of maintaining Z . **Two-regime degeneracy.** On the verifier channel, miscalibration acts on $m_{\phi}(\tau) = m_{\text{gen}} \cdot m_{\text{ver}}(\sigma)$ (VLM parse rate $\times$ verifier acceptance rate); the $\varepsilon_{\text{cal}} = 0$ guarantee holds vacuously when the accepted set is empty (cold-start: $m_{\text{ver}} \rightarrow 0$). Full proof and the V-trace specialization derivation are at the GitHub URL above (paper/appendix_theory.tex).

C Hyperparameters and Compute

Compute. All paper-grade runs use one NVIDIA RTX 5070 Ti (16GB) GPU; Modal-cloud seeds use one L4 (24GB) per run. Per-run wall-clock at 500k steps: ≈ 6 h SAC+HER, ≈ 9 h SAC+HER+VLM-CF (extra time is VLM-API latency, not compute). Total project compute: ~ 220 GPU-hours across local + Modal, plus $\sim \$80$ VLM-API spend. Snapshot round-trip latency for the verifier is 17.6 ms per call (a 0.4% overhead at ~ 1700 failed episodes / 100k steps). Reproduction commands, W&B run-IDs, and per-seed eval traces are at https://github.com/DJRGVC/RL_project_185 (commit 0fa36fc).

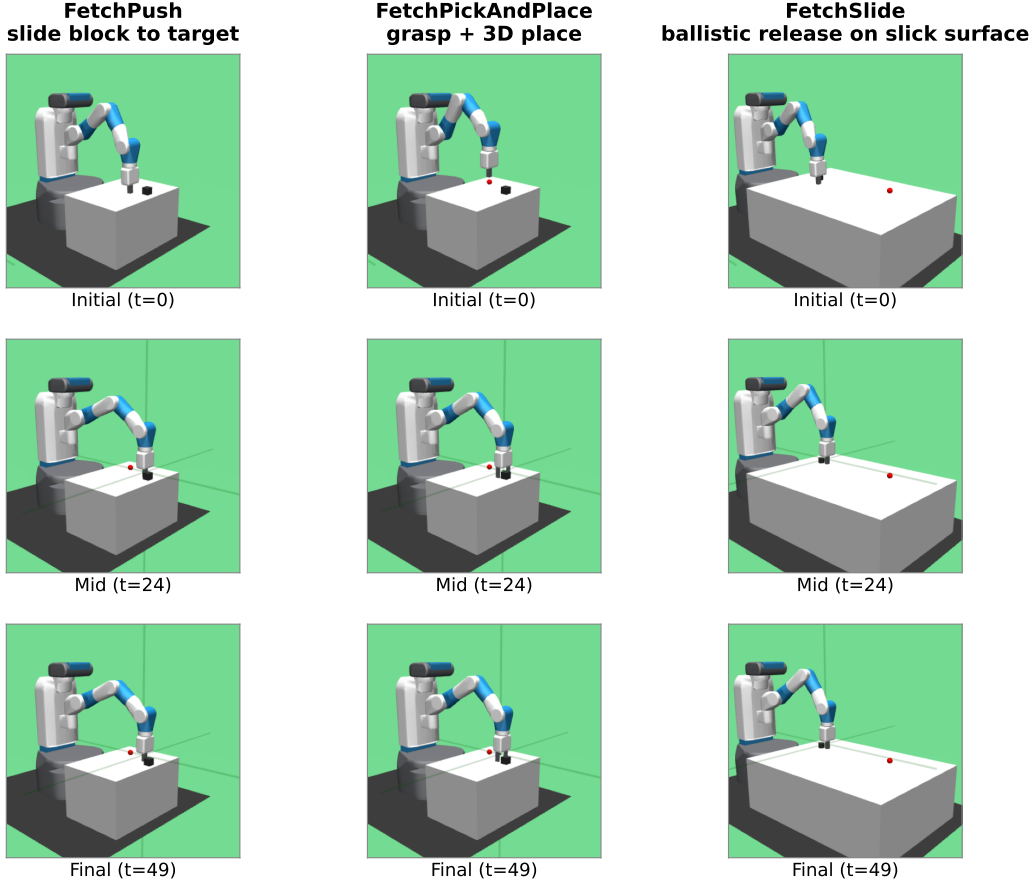


Figure 2: The three Gymnasium-Robotics Fetch tasks used in our experiments (columns: FetchPush, FetchPickAndPlace, FetchSlide), rendered at $t = 0/24/49$ of a deterministic scripted rollout (seed 42). Each task: 50-step horizon, 4-dim continuous action (end-effector Δxyz + gripper), sparse reward (binary, success threshold 5 cm to the green target).

D Additional Experimental Detail

Real-data validation (extended). The $n = 10$ real-failure set is failed eval episodes from partially-trained SAC+HER checkpoints (FetchPickAndPlace at 50k steps, FetchPush at 30k steps, both at $\sim 5\%$ success). These are near-misses with final-distance $\in [0.06, 0.34]$ m on Push and median 0.27 m on PickAndPlace. Three findings carry over from the synthetic set: **(i) Teleport-collapse persists and is task-conditioned.** On Push (planar target), Opus and Sonnet teleport on ACHIEVED_GOAL at 100% and 75%; on PickAndPlace (mid-air target), Opus teleports at 75% but Sonnet drops to 0%, proposing a mid-air waypoint ~ 8 cm above the floating goal. **(ii) The 5 cm reject-teleport gate is necessary.** Aggregated across both VLMs and position-emitting variants on 20 generations, the gate fires on 12 (60%); cross-vendor floor on Push is 75%. The action-emitting verifier sidesteps this. **(iii) Plausibility shifts only ± 0.07 synthetic-to-real, but the ACTION sign-flip rate worsens** (Opus 0.50 $\rightarrow$ 0.55, Sonnet 0.70).

Statistical methodology. Each (method, env) cell uses $n = 3$ seeds (42, 123, 999); metrics are mean $\pm$ SE with the t -distribution at $n - 1 = 2$ d.f. Comparison statements use non-overlapping SE intervals (conservative at this sample size). The load-bearing 0/6 vs. 4/4 contrast in Table 1 is judge-independent (Euclidean predicate); Fisher’s exact test rejects equal proportions at $p < 0.005$.

Cross-task transfer (per-episode notes). A 12-episode pilot (4 per env). The VLM’s reasoning strings identify task-specific modes correctly in every case (Push: “gripper passes over block without

Table 2: Headline hyperparameters. Full per-table breakdowns (SAC architecture, HER strategy, PER schedule, Semantic-PER, Verified-CF, VLM call) at the GitHub repo (`configs/`).

Parameter	Value	Notes
<i>SAC</i> [7]		
Hidden layers $\times$ width	2×256 , ReLU	Twin-Q; tanh-Gaussian actor
LR (actor/critic/ α)	3×10^{-4}	Adam, default $(\beta_1, \beta_2, \varepsilon)$
Discount γ / Polyak τ	0.98/0.005	Fetch-standard
Target entropy $\tilde{H}$	$-d_a = -4$	Auto-tuned
Batch / updates per step	256/1	10k warm-up uniform-random
<i>HER</i> [1]		
Strategy / k_{HER}	<code>future</code> / 4	4 hindsight transitions per real
<i>PER</i> [21]		
α / $\beta_0 \rightarrow \beta_{\text{end}}$	0.6/0.4 $\rightarrow$ 1.0	Linear over 500k steps; $\varepsilon = 10^{-6}$
<i>Semantic PER</i>		
Window half-width W	5 timesteps	11-slot box around t_{fail}
Boost cap w_{max}	10	Multiplicative factor on PER priority
Keyframes K / VLM provider	5 / GPT-4o (production)	<code>gpt-4o-2024-08-06</code>
<i>Verified-CF</i>		
Verifier rollout horizon N	50 steps	One Fetch episode
Success threshold η / teleport reject ρ	0.05/0.05 m	Env’s native threshold
CF prompt variant	ACTION	Structurally teleport-immune
<i>Training</i>		
Total env steps	500k (paper-grade)	250k–1M for selected ablations
Random seeds	42, 123, 999	3 per (method, env) cell
Replay capacity	10^6 slots	Ring buffer with sum-tree priorities

making contact”; PickAndPlace: “gripper at block location but fails to close”; Slide: “strike direction off-axis”). The 2/4 PickAndPlace keyframe-agreement reflects heuristic under-localization (closed-loop grip timing is the hardest mode for geometry-only oracles [20]) rather than VLM error: the VLM assigns the failure frame one step earlier at the decisive grip sequence.

E Broader Impacts and Reproducibility

Broader impact. Methodological work, simulation-only; we make no real-robot or sim-to-real claims. *Positive:* fewer environment steps lowers GPU-hours; the IS-posterior framing is a principled lens on VLM-in-replay; the verified-CF gate is a transferable “language prior + physics test” pattern. *Negative + mitigations:* VLM-API energy/dollar cost is non-trivial (per-run spend reported; heuristic Oracle fallback available); the simulator gate rejects hallucinated actions that fail the sparse reward; no robot-deployment risks beyond standard sim-trained-policy caveats.

Reproducibility. Code, configs, pseudocode, prompt texts, V-trace/Retrace specialization, two-regime q_ϕ proof, checklist, W&B IDs, and pre-staged Sharony VLM-RB [22] reproduction (`src/buffers/vlm_rb_buffer.py`, head-to-head deferred to camera-ready) at https://github.com/DJRGVC/RL_project_185 (0fa36fc).